全民英檢中級 GEPT Intermediate | 第 30 單元 | 語言與表達 · Language & Expression

Why Does Everyone in Taiwan Sound a Little Different?

為什麼臺灣每個人的口音都有點不一樣？

If you take the train from Taipei to Kaohsiung, you will hear Mandarin spoken with a slightly different accent at almost every stop. A friend from Tainan may stretch a vowel that a Taipei speaker cuts short, and a grandmother in Yilan might slip in a word from the Taiwanese dialect that her grandchildren only half understand. Linguists define a dialect as a form of a language shared by a particular group, while an accent refers only to the way words are pronounced. The two are often confused, so the distinction is worth clarifying.

Neither an accent nor a dialect is 'wrong.' Each one conveys information about where a speaker grew up, who raised them, and sometimes even which television programs they watched as a child. Problems arise only when people criticize a way of speaking they do not share. A student who is told that her southern accent sounds 'funny' may stop speaking in class altogether. Consequently, she loses the chance to practice the very skill she is being judged on.

Context also matters. The same expression can be a compliment in one town and a joke in another, and a farewell that sounds warm in Hakka may seem abrupt when translated directly into Mandarin. Good communicators learn to pay attention to these signals instead of exaggerating the differences. When a misunderstanding happens, a short explanation, or even a simple apology, usually clears the air faster than an argument about who is 'correct.'

The next time you chat with someone whose speech sounds unfamiliar, listen for the consonants they soften and the words they emphasize. You might discover that the person you were about to criticize is giving you a free lesson in the history of the island. Language is not only a tool for conveying ideas; it is also a map of where we have all come from.

重點單字 Key Vocabulary

單字	詞性	中文	例句

accent	*n.*	口音	The tour guide speaks English with a strong French accent. 那位導遊說英文帶有濃濃的法國口音。
dialect	*n.*	方言	My grandfather speaks a dialect that few young people understand. 我爺爺說的方言，很少年輕人聽得懂。
define	*v.*	定義	The dictionary defines 'courage' as the ability to face fear. 字典把「勇氣」定義為面對恐懼的能力。
clarify	*v.*	澄清；說清楚	Could you clarify what you mean by 'soon'? 你能說清楚你說的「很快」是什麼意思嗎？
convey	*v.*	傳達	A picture can convey feelings that words cannot. 一張圖片能傳達文字無法表達的感受。
criticize	*v.*	批評	It is easy to criticize, but hard to do better. 批評很容易，但要做得更好很難。
consequently	*adv.*	因此；結果	He missed the bus and, consequently, arrived late for the exam. 他錯過公車，因此考試遲到了。
context	*n.*	上下文；語境	You can often guess a word's meaning from its context. 你通常可以從上下文猜出一個字的意思。
compliment	*n.*	讚美	She received many compliments on her new haircut. 她的新髮型得到許多讚美。
exaggerate	*v.*	誇大	My brother always exaggerates how big the fish he caught was. 我哥總是誇大他釣到的魚有多大。

片語 Phrases

slip in	不經意地加入（話語）	The speaker slipped in a joke to wake up the audience. 講者不經意地加了一個笑話來喚醒聽眾。
pay attention to	注意	Please pay attention to the announcements on the MRT. 請注意捷運上的廣播。
clear the air	消除誤會；化解尷尬	A frank talk helped the two friends clear the air. 一次坦誠的談話幫助兩位朋友消除了誤會。

文法與句型 Grammar

Neither + A + nor + B + V (單數)

neither A nor B 意思是「A 和 B 都不…」，動詞的單複數依最接近的 B 決定。文中 Neither an accent nor a dialect is wrong 表示兩者都沒有錯。

Neither my sister nor my brother likes spicy food.

我姊姊和我弟弟都不喜歡吃辣。

the way (that / in which) + S + V

the way 後面接子句，表示「…的方式」，that 或 in which 常省略。文中 the way words are pronounced 指「字詞被發音的方式」。

I like the way she explains difficult ideas.

我喜歡她解釋困難概念的方式。

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